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University evaluation-selection: a Turkish case

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University
evaluation-
selection

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Abstract

Purpose – The purpose of this study is to examine the university selection criteria of students for better university management with the use of marketing tools.

Design/methodology/approach – This study consists of a survey on students attending a foundation university in Turkey. The questionnaire method has been chosen in order to determine the important criteria having an impact on the student views towards university selection. The students had been admitted to a foundation university in the 2005-2006 period when within the same universities various departments were included in the study.

Findings – The results indicate student evaluation and selection criteria in this period of time.

Practical implications – This paper examines the criteria that affects the selection of students and, in detail the students' point of view towards the university evaluation and selection in Turkey. This will help the university manager's decision making on the marketing tools they use.

Originality/value – Selecting a university is a long-term commitment and a very important decision for the high school students and/or graduates. Academic, social, physical factors and facilities are some important criteria for university selection. This study concerns the importance of these criteria in detail.

Keywords Universities, Promotional methods, Consumer behaviour, Selection, Turkey

Paper type Research paper

Introduction

There are several application processes and recruitment implementations all around the world in the higher education market. The recruitment structures and college admissions vary widely from country to country (<http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/CollegeAdmissions>, accessed 25 December 2005). For example, nearly all British higher education institutions are members of the UCAS (Universities & Colleges Admissions Service, available at: <http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/UCAS>, accessed 25 December 2005), therefore, nearly all those wishing to study for their first degrees in the UK have to apply through the UCAS. In the USA, students apply to one or more colleges or universities by submitting an application which each college evaluates according to its own criteria. For the graduate education virtually all graduate programs require applicants to submit scores on standardized tests (Cushing and McGarvey, 2004). Australia uses the law of the Federal System of Government, regarding education and admission to the Technical and Further Education Colleges and to universities offering undergraduate degrees for domestic students, in the domain of the state and territory government. In Turkey the Student Selection and Placement Center (ÖSYM) prepares the centralized University Entrance Examination.

Today's marketplace faces an intensified and rapid change of competition in the market, fostered by factors such as globalisation, maturing markets and rapid technological change (Santoro and Chakrabarti, 2002). As a result of increased national and international competition more and more research institutions and universities are



under pressure to find new ways to generate income (Baaken, 2005). Since the 1990s, universities have become much more marketing focused in the competition to reach their goals ahead (Farr, 2003). According to Drummond (2004) the expansion and commercialization of higher education has seen the wide scale adoption of marketing techniques within the sector.

Hanna (1989) pointed out that higher education institutions maintain both external and internal images. In this study the company image is a composite of images held by the institution's external and internal of its members. These images have lots of importance in the selection process. Socio-cultural factors are defined by the students' perceptions of their cultural capital (Marcoulides *et al.*, 2005). According to these studies, there are several factors and criteria that affect the students who evaluate and select a university.

Literature review

There are several studies which contain various criteria which students use to select a major in a college (Strasser *et al.*, 2002). They found that these factors were divided into three clusters interest in study, influence of others, and careers that include compensation. Kaynama and Smith (1996) found influence of others important for pre-business students. They also found job availability impacting a student's decision. According to Belanger *et al.* (2002), the organisational literature, campus staff and students and other networking efforts are among the factors influencing the selection of the university.

Trim (2003) asserts the importance of professional relationships and relationship marketing approaches for customer expectations. Hill *et al.* (2003) have evaluated the quality of the academicians and student support systems as being the best factors in educational marketing and educational quality.

University marketing communication tools as external factors that affect selection are also discussed by several authors. Gilley (1989) explained how radio, television newspaper and magazine can be used to attract publicity. Steele (2002) conducted studies on how to build effective communication with college and university students using the catalogue, application tools, and program materials. According to Mayer *et al.* (1999), communication technologies, (Katz *et al.*, 1999), such as CD's and DVDs in university advertising (Furbeck *et al.*, 2004) and web page properties (Erdal, 2001), have been considered before. Brochures, posters, meetings, sponsorships and billboards, web pages, TV and newspaper advertisements are mostly used as some communication tools for university selection.

According to Donaldson and McNicholas (2004), the reputation, nature of the courses, location and address, financial considerations, facilities, social climate of the department, programme structure and accreditation factors influence student choice of institution and course for post graduate studies. The student generated (Strasser *et al.* (2002) criteria include:

- (1) *Interest in the subject:*
 - personal preference;
 - ability in handling the subject matter;
 - rigorous/challenging; and
 - enjoyable/fun.

(2) *Influence of others:*

- advisors;
- parents; and
- peers.

(3) *Career:*

- compensation – earning potential and earning growth;
- job availability and growth – employment opportunity and advancement opportunity;
- job requirements – dealing with people and team work.

According to Soutar and Turner (2002), there are mainly three market segments in the Australian university market. These segments are high school graduates, elderly students, and international students that have been influenced by several factors while selecting the best university for them. Some of these factors are below:

- the course or programme they want to follow (e.g. business, international relations, music etc.);
- academic reputation;
- location;
- ranking of the school;
- the quality of academic personnel;
- the degree of being classic or contemporary;
- friends who go to the same university;
- family and/or 3rd parties' suggestions; and
- cost for the students.

Important factors for evaluation and selection of a university

Evaluative criteria are the various features or benefits a consumer looks for in response to making a decision and are used in the process by which consumers evaluate and choose among alternatives as indicated in Figure 1 (Hawkins *et al.*, 1998). Some of these criteria are reputation, cost, quality, the awareness and response of the universities to the high school students and graduates.

According to the type of evaluation criteria, a consumer uses in a decision varies from tangible (e.g. cost, people, etc.) to intangible (e.g. procedures, reputation etc.) factors (Hawkins *et al.*, 1998 and Cirone, 2003). For example academic, social and physical factors and facilities are some important criteria for university selection. Interest is another important criterion in the model developed by Kaynama and Smith (1996).

The number of evaluative criteria used depends on the product (service), the consumer, and the situation. For fairly simple products, the numbers of evaluative criteria used are few (Wahlers, 1982). The criteria students use to evaluate the universities that constitute their evoked sets (a list of brand name universities, which they plan to select) usually are expressed in terms of important product/service attributes (Schiffman and Kanuk, 1997). For higher education, these criteria are

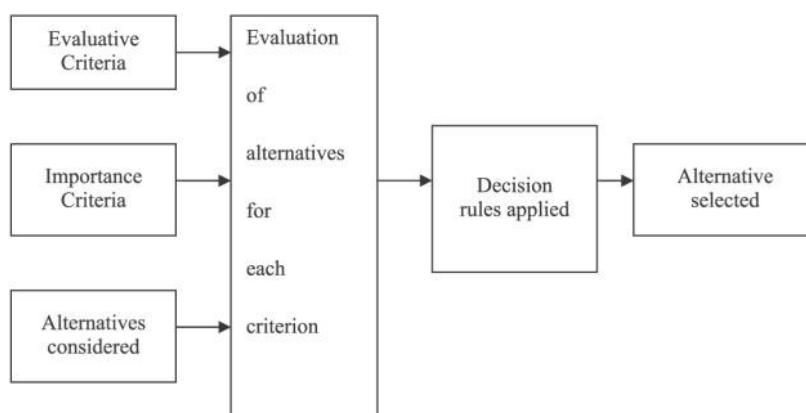


Figure 1.
Alternative evaluation and
selection process

Source: Hawkins *et al.* (1998)

generally affected by marketing communication tools such as advertisements and public relations concerning reputation and ranking of school. After graduation, obtaining employment is also another criterion for the selection.

Methodology and sample

This study consists of a survey about enrolled students in foundation universities in Turkey. The questionnaire method has been chosen in order to determine the important criteria that has an impact on the student views concerning university selection. The questionnaire consists of three sections. The issues related with preparing the questionnaires are university marketing communication tools, the elements affecting the students' selection of the university, and personal information. Education, social status, knowledge, and experience are the characteristics of the participants taken into consideration when preparing the questionnaire questions and special concepts were noted to avoid ambiguity for the participants.

This is the following questionnaire of the 2004-2005 Student Promotional Survey of the same foundation university established in 1999 in Turkey. The same questionnaire had been examined in the academic year 2005-2006. Questionnaires were given to the students as face-to-face interviews. Although likely answers of the participants were carefully considered, while making room for "other" optional answers, the "other" optional questions stood in the questionnaire for exceptional answers from the students.

This study had been conducted in a foundation university that started its academic performance in 2002 in Istanbul, the biggest metropolitan city with a population of 10.033.478 according to the Statistical Institute of Turkey in the year 2000.

The students who had been admitted to a foundation university in the 2005-2006 periods in the same universities with various departments included in the study. 153 respondents received face-to-face questionnaires in the study. The questionnaires were given to the students while they were given to the students admitted according to university standards. The profile of all the students subjected to the questionnaire were as follows: 45 per cent of the students were 17 years old, 31 per cent of them were 18

years old, 14 per cent were 19 years old, and others were older than 20 years. Most of the students were newly graduated from high schools. Of the respondents, 51 per cent were females and 49 per cent of the other respondents were males.

The department students enrolled in universities is given in Figure 2. Accordingly, the Economics and Business Administration Faculty students hold the majority with 39 per cent and students from the Humanities and Arts Faculty hold 29 per cent of the shares in their responses respectively. The department of Computer and Tourism School has 16 per cent and the department of Engineering has 16 per cent shares of the total responses.

Findings

University selection influence

There are several influences considered in this study for selecting a university. Some of the influences are personal preference, parents, university entrance exam scores, university ranking, advisors, and friends. Most of them considered as external and situational influences.

When we look at the general selection factors, personal preference becomes the most influential factor in university selection. (See Figure 3). Almost 87 per cent of the students made their decisions according to their own preferences. The student's university selection depended on the student's own decision without any outside influence.

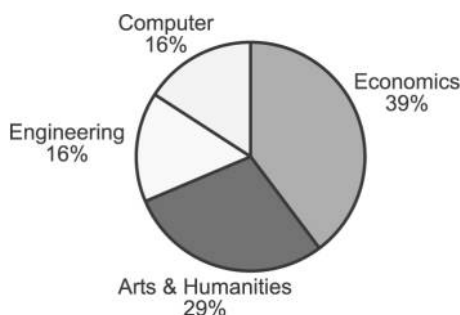


Figure 2.
Distribution of students
according to faculties and
schools

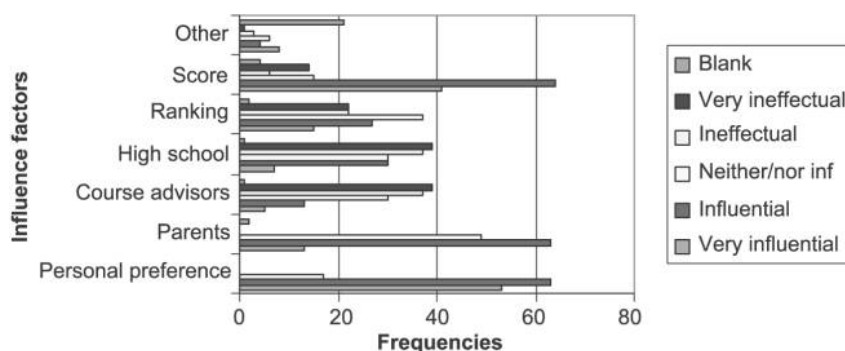


Figure 3.
University selection
influence factors for
students

In the decision making process, parents have also a great influence in the selection process. The family's influence also has had a high impact on the student's selection with 59 per cent.

Score is another important influence in university selection in Turkey. Students pass through the Student Selection and Placement Test in the Higher Education System of Turkey and the score obtained from this test is 73 per cent influential in the students' selection of a university.

On the other hand, the course and high school advisors are not very influential in this study however almost all students go to the university preparation courses. The effect of private course advisors rests only at 10 per cent respectively.

Universities increasingly employ marketing communication tools in addition to conventional ones for promotion and success. Listed from classical to technological, they include student affairs, public relations, promotion, advertisements, fairs, sponsorships, web sites, etc. The modern promotional tools employed in university marketing are: the web page, e-mail, mobile communication, and other virtual communication as well as the conventional telephone, along with the public relations and promotions departments.

The findings regarding the second question which measures the levels of impact created by promotions on the students regarding university promotion are given in Table I.

Accordingly, more students are affected from the web page than from any other source. Then come families, friends, and advertisements. Promotions in high schools, fairs, and newspaper advertisements are apparently not as influential as the others in terms of percentage. According to the results obtained, the following order of importance has been determined for the defined advertising tools. Among the classical advertising tools, TV has the highest impact while newspaper, magazine, and web page follow behind. Web pages are getting more influential than before. Because radio advertising is not used frequently in Turkey, it remained in fourth place in terms of influence.

The seminars given in high schools are prominent among the elements affecting the students' university selection. Promotional CD and the campus presentations follow it. Private course promotions and private course guidance teachers come in second and third place as important promotional elements. CDs seem less important. Here, web site and internet are in last place.

The frequencies of the questions regarding the level of importance the elements important for promotion as predetermined by the creator of the questionnaire are given in Figure 4.

Rank	Elements in university selection	(%)
1	Web page	28
2	Families	19
3	Friends	17
4	Advertisements	16
5	Fairs	10
6	High school visits	7
7	Newspapers	2

Table I.
Issues which have an
influence in university
promotion

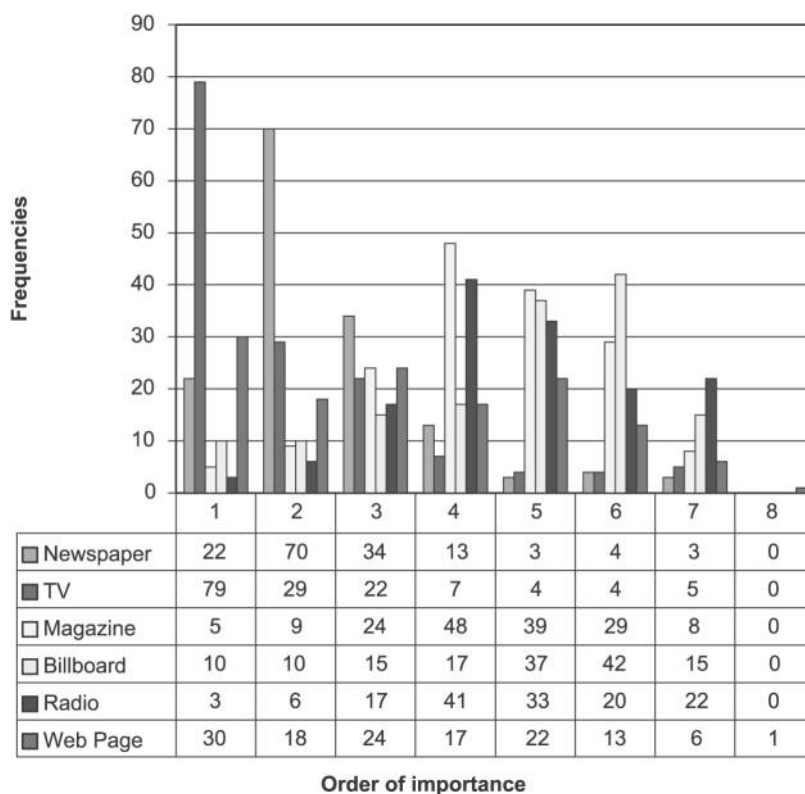


Figure 4.
Importance of advertising
tools

We wanted to determine the importance levels of the element that leads students to choose a university they enrolled in is given in the graphics.

Students consider the issue of universities being a promising one for the future so that they would not have any problems in finding employment after graduation (see Figure 5).

Furthermore, ones' existence in a large city like Istanbul with more than 10 million people live, proximity to home, easy transportation are critical factors in selecting a university (see Figure 6).

The advantages of foreign language classes and teaching staff are very important. According to the results, the factors study fees and the score earned on the university entrance exam tend to be parallel with each other and are determined to be important issues in selecting a university (Figure 7).

According to the results, the provided post-educational benefits, departments, and the campus seem important. Social and sports facilities follow it. The academic and the social environment come after.

Limitations

It is important to point out that there are several limitations in this study. Our biggest concern about this study is that this research has been implemented in only one

Figure 5.
Commitment and
employment after
graduation

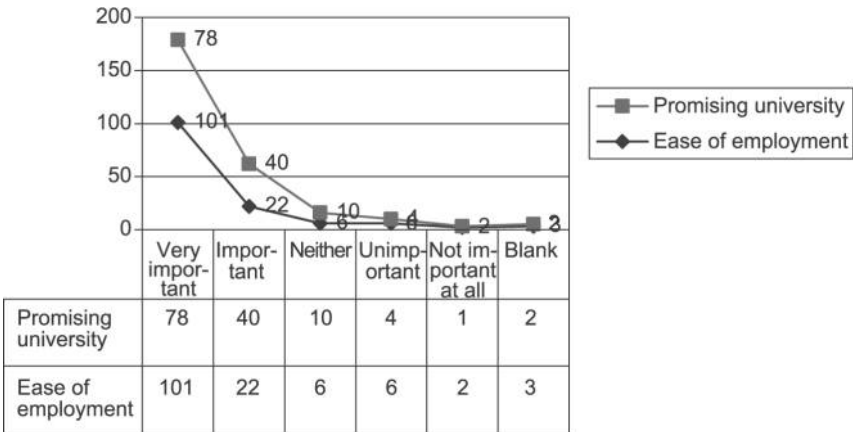


Figure 6.
Importance of
transportation and
location in selection

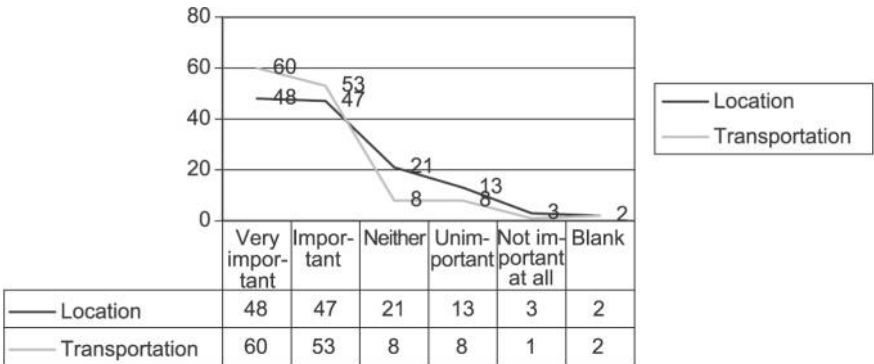
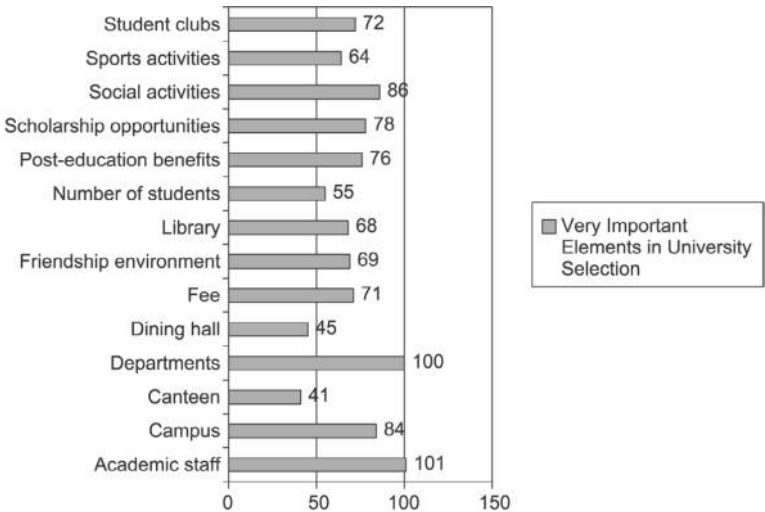


Figure 7.
Importance of elements in
university selection



university which means only the commitment of one foundation university's students enrolled in the 2005-2006 semester is included in this research. However, there are several public and private universities in Istanbul and Turkey. This means a very limited number of students were surveyed. In this study; perception, learning, memory, motives, personality, emotions and attitudes are not discussed in detail.

Conclusion

As a result of fostering competition, there are several marketing activities that should be conducted by universities to be selected. The approaches in university marketing are in the winds of change and their transformation into a professional activity is an ongoing process affecting university marketing communication tools for university management. The university may present its image in a good manner with a good understanding of its students' perceptions.

A questionnaire has been developed in order to measure the elements influencing the decision making process of university students and the effect marketing communication tools has on them. For countries like Turkey, which has a centralized testing and system of student selection and placement, the scores obtained in the university entrance examinations are also highly important in the selection of a university. This factor can be regarded as an external one. Families are also very influential when one is selecting a university. The efforts also directed to families should be required carefully because families have an active role in selection and enrollment. Also, elements such as advising guidance teachers are not very important for candidates who would like to make their own decisions.

Because web pages are gaining importance regarding the promotion of universities, these pages should be developed according to the needs of the market. An active web page is on the top of the list containing items such as advertisement visits and fairs influencing the potential student. The benefits of the classical approach should not be disregarded and its coherent tools should be taken advantage of while performing marketing activities in universities. As a matter of fact, it is stated that the most important tool in learning and evaluating a university is TV in Turkey. Newspapers, magazines, and billboards follow TV programmes.

Furthermore, different and brand new domains arise along with the continuing progress of technology and accordingly, new tools should be developed to bring in new horizons. The integrated approach requires the combined consideration of elements such as target audience, cost, results, planning, evaluation, and selection of universities to be carried out based on a clear understanding.

University management should also spend efforts to develop a visionary and strategic perspective on the subject that should take the students, teaching staff, society, and other stakeholders into consideration. Therefore, the available tools should be employed in the right place at the right time and in the right way.

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